

Writing Economics

A Short Guide to Research Writing in Economics

Adapted from *Writing Economics: A Guide for Harvard Economics Concentrators*

Why Writing Matters in Economics

- Economics studies a wide range of topics, from individual choice to public policy.
- Economists do not only describe the world; they explain behavior under constraints.
- Writing is essential because research becomes meaningful only when it is communicated clearly.
- Good economics writing helps readers understand:
 - the research question,
 - the logic of the argument,
 - the evidence used,
 - and the conclusions drawn.

What Makes Economics Writing Different?

- Economics writing is mainly a form of **technical writing**.
- The main goal is **clarity**, not literary elegance.
- A strong paper should make the analysis easy to follow.
- Good economics writing does not “just happen”:
 - it requires preparation,
 - careful research,
 - planning,
 - and revision.

The Four Keys to Good Economics Writing

Core Principles

- ① **Research** — know the literature and, for empirical work, the data.
- ② **Analysis** — move beyond description to careful reasoning.
- ③ **Organization** — present ideas, methods, and findings in a logical structure.
- ④ **Clarity** — revise until the writing becomes simple, direct, and efficient.

A paper can have a good idea but still fail if the argument is weakly organized or unclearly written.

How to Improve Clarity

- Clearly state the research question or hypothesis.
- Build the paper around a clear argument.
- Avoid unnecessary words.
- Revise seriously and repeatedly.
- Prefer direct and simple sentences.

Useful Style Rules

- Use the **active voice**.
- Put statements in **positive form**.
- **Omit needless words**.
- Generally stick to **one tense**.

Three Main Types of Economics Papers

Type	Main Focus
Theory Paper	Builds, extends, critiques, or clarifies an economic model.
Empirical Paper	Uses data and statistical methods to test hypotheses or measure relationships.
Combo Paper	Combines theoretical reasoning with empirical analysis.

These three forms reflect different but related ways economists study causal relationships.

The Theory Paper

- A theory paper explains some aspect of the world through a model.
- Economic models are simplified representations of reality.
- They usually distinguish between:
 - **Exogenous variables**: inputs determined outside the model,
 - **Endogenous variables**: outputs determined within the model.
- A theory paper may:
 - propose a new model,
 - extend an existing model,
 - or critique its assumptions and implications.
- Good theory papers also explain the intuition behind the mathematics.

The Empirical Paper

- An empirical paper tests theories and measures relationships using data.
- It asks questions such as:
 - How much does schooling raise earnings?
 - How much does police presence reduce crime?
- Economists often use observational data from the real world.
- Statistical tools help identify patterns and estimate causal effects.
- Empirical work may use methods such as:
 - OLS,
 - instrumental variables,
 - regression discontinuity,
 - randomized controlled trials.

The Combo Paper

- Some papers combine theory and evidence.
- A theoretical framework may guide the empirical analysis.
- Empirical findings may motivate a new theoretical explanation.
- Data may also be used to calibrate a model or test its implications.

Why This Type Is Powerful

It connects abstract reasoning with real-world evidence, which often makes the paper more persuasive and policy-relevant.

Finding and Narrowing a Topic

- Getting started is often the hardest part of research.
- Begin with a broad area that genuinely interests you.
- Then narrow it into a specific, manageable research question.
- A good topic should be:
 - interesting,
 - feasible,
 - relevant to the assignment,
 - and supported by available literature or data.
- Avoid topics that are too broad to answer within the time and length constraints.

Research as a Sequence of Small Tasks

A Practical Strategy

Break the project into smaller steps:

- ① choose a topic,
 - ② search the literature,
 - ③ read abstracts,
 - ④ select key papers,
 - ⑤ find data,
 - ⑥ conduct analysis,
 - ⑦ draft the paper,
 - ⑧ revise carefully.
- Set deadlines for each stage.
 - Clear up confusion about the assignment early.
 - Leave enough time for revision.

Finding and Using Sources

- Economics research uses two broad types of sources:
 - ① **Academic literature** — journal articles, books, working papers.
 - ② **Data** — numerical information such as prices, income, employment, or survey results.
- Literature helps you:
 - understand what others have done,
 - identify debates,
 - and locate a gap for your own contribution.
- Data help you test ideas and quantify relationships.

Taking Notes and Organizing Materials

- Keep careful notes on everything you read.
- For each source, record:
 - the main argument,
 - the data and methods,
 - the main findings,
 - and your own comments.
- Clearly distinguish direct quotations from your own wording.
- Organize notes by topic, theme, or chronology.
- Citation software can help manage references consistently.

Good note-taking also reduces the risk of plagiarism.

Citations and References

- Citing sources is a matter of:
 - honesty,
 - credibility,
 - and courtesy.
- In economics, sources are usually cited briefly in the text.
- Full bibliographic details appear in the **References** section.
- When quoting directly, include the page number.
- Whatever citation style you choose, use it consistently.

Important Reminder

Poor note-taking and weak documentation can lead to unintentional plagiarism.

Typical Structure of a Research Paper

- ➊ Introduction
- ➋ Review of Relevant Literature
- ➌ Data and Methodology
- ➍ Results
- ➎ Discussion of Findings
- ➏ References

Final Message

A strong economics paper asks a clear question, uses appropriate theory or evidence, and communicates the argument in a well-organized and concise way.

What to Write in the Introduction

- **Start with the research topic and context.**
- **State the research question clearly.**
- **Explain why the question matters.**
- **Briefly mention the approach or method.**
- **Preview the main contribution of the paper.**

The Introduction should answer:

- What is this paper about?
- Why is this question important?
- What does this paper do?
- What is the main result or contribution?

What to Write in the Literature Review

- Summarize the most relevant previous studies.
- Group the literature by theme, method, or finding.
- Show how earlier studies are related to your question.
- Identify gaps, limitations, or unresolved issues.
- Explain how your paper differs from or adds to the literature.

The Literature Review should answer:

- What do we already know about this topic?
- What have other researchers found?
- What is still missing?
- Where does this paper fit in?

What to Write in Data and Methodology

- Describe the data source(s).
- Define the sample, variables, and time period.
- Explain how key variables are measured.
- Present the model, empirical strategy, or theoretical framework.
- Justify why this method is suitable for the research question.

This section should answer:

- What data are used?
- How are variables constructed?
- What method or model is applied?
- Why is this approach appropriate?

What to Write in the Results Section

- Present the main findings in a clear order.
- Use tables, figures, or equations where appropriate.
- Explain the meaning of coefficients, signs, and magnitudes.
- Relate the findings to the research question.
- Report robustness checks or alternative specifications if relevant.

The Results section should answer:

- What did the analysis find?
- Are the results statistically and economically meaningful?
- Do the findings support the hypothesis?

What to Write in the Discussion and Conclusion

- Interpret the findings in economic terms.
- Explain how the results connect to theory or prior studies.
- Discuss policy implications or practical significance.
- Acknowledge limitations of the paper.
- Suggest directions for future research.

This section should answer:

- What do these results mean?
- Why do they matter?
- What are the limitations?
- What can be studied next?